

Notions of God — Premium Solved-PYQ and Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional · Paper II · Philosophy of Religion · 2026 Edition

How to use this workbook

1. Read the demand decoding, then close the model answer and write within the indicated time.
2. Compare your script with the top-answer requirements, not merely with the conclusion.
3. Attempt the MCQs without looking at the explanation. The key rotates strictly $A \rightarrow B \rightarrow C \rightarrow D$.
4. For Mains practice, preserve the philosophical sequence: definition $\rightarrow$ doctrine/argument $\rightarrow$ distinction $\rightarrow$ objection/reply $\rightarrow$ graded verdict.
5. Do not interchange four different relations: identity, dependent appearance, metaphysical embodiment, and efficient causation.

Part I — All Verified Notions-of-God PYQs (2018–2024)

Corpus note: The audited Paper II corpus contains 13 topic-owned PYQs from 2018–2024. There was no primary topic-owned “Notions of God” PYQ in 2025.

PYQ 1 — 2018, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact question

“Is Hinduism poly-theistic? Give reasons for your answer.”

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Take a reasoned position, not a yes/no vote
Core issue	Whether plurality of Hindu deities entails metaphysical polytheism
Scope boundary	Classify Hindu traditions; do not attempt a history of Hinduism
Ideal thesis	Hinduism has polytheistic forms, but “polytheistic” alone is philosophically inadequate because henotheistic, monotheistic, monistic and qualified-theistic structures coexist

Model answer

Hinduism is polytheistic at the level of ritual plurality, since many deities possess distinct names, forms, myths and devotional communities. Yet this description is not exhaustive. Vedic religion is often better described as henotheistic or kathenotheistic: several gods are acknowledged, while one is praised as supreme in a given hymn or context. Bhakti traditions may subordinate other deities to one supreme Vishnu, Siva or Devi, thus approximating monotheism without denying sacred plurality.

Its philosophical schools complicate the label further. Advaita regards deities and Saguna Ishvara as valid at the empirical level but makes Nirguna Brahman the non-dual ultimate. Ramanuja affirms one personal Brahman qualified by real souls and world. Nyaya posits one omniscient Ishvara as cosmic governor. Thus plurality may signify independent gods, manifestations, names, powers, or subordinate forms, depending on the tradition.

Therefore, Hinduism contains polytheism, but cannot be reduced to it. "Plural religious forms with diverse metaphysical interpretations" is the more accurate verdict.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: descriptive plurality → classificatory distinctions → school-wise evidence → qualified verdict.
- Doctrine: polytheism, henotheism, kathenotheism, monotheism and monism.
- Argument: many forms do not by themselves prove many independent ultimate realities.
- Technical terms: ishta-devata, Saguna Ishvara, Nirguna Brahman.
- Comparison: Vedic praise, bhakti supremacy, Advaita, Visishtadvaita and Nyaya.
- Criticism/evaluation: avoid imposing one Western category upon internally diverse traditions.
- Conclusion: "contains" polytheism but is not simply or uniformly polytheistic.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define polytheism; state qualified thesis
 4 min : Ritual plurality + henotheism/kathenotheism
 2 min : Advaita, Ramanuja, Nyaya
 1 min : Reasoned verdict
 Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Calling Hinduism simply monotheistic because "truth is one": erases real plurality.
- Calling monism a form of monotheism: category confusion.
- Listing deities without philosophical classification: descriptive, not analytical.
- Claiming all deities are identical in every school: historically and doctrinally false.
- Giving a sociological answer without God-world metaphysics: low optional value.

PYQ 2 — 2019, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"State and evaluate the personalistic and impersonalistic aspects of God."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	First state both models, then assess their philosophical adequacy
Core issue	Whether ultimacy is best conceived as purposive personality or transpersonal absolute
Scope boundary	Focus on the God-concept, not proofs of existence
Ideal thesis	Personalism secures religious relation; impersonalism secures infinity and non-anthropomorphism; neither is cost-free

Model answer

A personalistic conception attributes to God intelligence, will, purposive agency and relational capacities such as knowledge, love and response. Classical theism conceives God as a personal creator, while Ramanuja's Brahman is the supreme personal Narayana endowed with infinite auspicious qualities. Such a God makes prayer, providence, grace, command and moral accountability intelligible. "Personal," however, need not mean embodied or finite; divine personality is usually predicated analogically.

An impersonalistic conception treats ultimate reality as exceeding person-like volition. Spinoza's Deus sive Natura is the one infinite substance from whose nature modes follow necessarily. Sankara's Nirguna Brahman is non-dual reality beyond limiting predicates; Saguna Ishvara belongs to the empirical standpoint. Impersonalism avoids anthropomorphism and preserves metaphysical absoluteness, unity and necessity.

Both models face difficulties. Personalism risks projecting finite psychology upon infinity and must reconcile divine goodness with evil and immutability with response. Impersonalism weakens petitionary prayer, grace and moral address; Spinoza's God does not choose, while Advaita ultimately sublates the worshipper-worshipped distinction.

Advaita hierarchically relates the two, whereas Visishtadvaita makes personality ultimate. Neither position can simply annex the other: adding will to an impersonal Absolute changes its causal grammar, while stripping a personal God of agency weakens its religious function. A graded conclusion is preferable: personalism better explains lived religion, while impersonalism better guards transcendence from anthropomorphic limitation. An adequate conception must show how personality can be perfect without becoming finite.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: precise definitions → Western and Indian formulations → strengths → objections → comparative verdict.
- Doctrine: classical theism, Spinoza, Advaita and Visishtadvaita.
- Argument: personality explains relation; impersonality explains absoluteness.
- Technical terms: analogical predication, Deus sive Natura, Nirguna, Saguna, vyavaharika, paramarthika.
- Comparison: do not equate Spinoza's substance with Advaita Brahman.
- Criticism: anthropomorphism versus religious remoteness.
- Conclusion: qualified, not an indiscriminate "both are true."

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Definitions and thesis
 5 min : Personalism—two traditions, strength, problem
 5 min : Impersonalism—two traditions, strength, problem
 1 min : Comparative verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Treating "personal" as physically human-shaped: conceptual error.
- Treating "impersonal" as unconscious matter: serious distortion.
- Writing only Saguna versus Nirguna: insufficient Western coverage.
- Claiming Advaita grants equal ultimacy to Ishvara and Nirguna Brahman: wrong level distinction.
- Ending with "both are complementary" without showing how: unsupported synthesis.

PYQ 3 — 2019, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the relationship between man and God according to any one of the religions in India."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain a relation systematically and evaluate its consequences
Core issue	Ontological, moral and soteriological relation between human self and God

Element	Requirement
Scope boundary	Choose one Indian religious-philosophical tradition and sustain it
Ideal thesis	In Ramanuja's Visishtadvaita, the jiva is real, distinct and responsible, yet inseparable from and wholly dependent upon God

Model answer

In Ramanuja's Visishtadvaita, the relation between man and God is neither numerical identity nor external dualism. Reality is one Brahman qualified by cit, conscious selves, and acit, non-conscious matter. The individual jiva is therefore a real and eternal mode or qualifier of Brahman.

Ramanuja explains this through the sarira-sariri relation. As a body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its indwelling self, so every jiva is the "body" of God, who is the inner controller (antaryamin). The relation is aprthak-siddhi: the self is distinct from God but cannot exist independently of God. Hence jiva $\neq$ Brahman, although the jiva is inseparably dependent upon Brahman.

This ontology grounds religious life. The person remains a genuine knower, agent and bearer of karma; devotion is therefore not directed by an illusory self toward a provisional deity. Bondage contracts the self's manifested consciousness, while liberation expands it through knowledge, bhakti, prapatti and divine grace. Moksha is loving communion and service, not Advaitic dissolution of individuality.

The body analogy preserves unity and difference, but raises the objection that embodied evil may implicate God. Ramanuja distinguishes defects of the dependent body from the perfection of its controller, though the problem of divine responsibility remains. The model thus converts metaphysical dependence into the basis of moral responsibility and devotion. The relationship is best described as distinct, dependent and inseparable communion.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: school selection $\rightarrow$ ontology $\rightarrow$ relation $\rightarrow$ moral agency $\rightarrow$ liberation $\rightarrow$ objection.
- Doctrine: Ishvara-cit-acit and qualified non-dualism.
- Argument: body criteria establish control, support and purposiveness.
- Technical terms: sarira-sariri, antaryamin, aprthak-siddhi, bhakti, prapatti.
- Comparison: contrast with Advaita identity without drifting into a general Vedanta essay.
- Criticism: evil in God's body and divine responsibility.
- Conclusion: individuality survives dependence and liberation.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Select Ramanuja; state distinct-but-inseparable thesis
 6 min : cit-acit + body relation + aprthak-siddhi
 3 min : karma, bhakti, prapatti, moksha
 2 min : objection, reply, verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Saying the jiva "is God" in Ramanuja: major doctrinal error.
- Using "body" literally or anthropomorphically: misreads technical analogy.
- Omitting soteriology: relationship remains incomplete.
- Treating prapatti as fatalistic passivity: distorts agency and grace.
- Comparing several religions despite "any one": loss of depth and time.

PYQ 4 — 2020, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact question

“Is there any compatibility between ‘Freedom of Will’ and ‘Omnipotent God’? Discuss.”

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Present incompatibilist pressure and a defensible reconciliation
Core issue	Whether maximal divine power excludes genuine creaturely agency
Scope boundary	Omnipotence is central; mention foreknowledge only as a connected but distinct problem
Ideal thesis	Compatibility is possible if omnipotence means power over all logically possible states and God voluntarily permits secondary agency

Model answer

Omnipotence should mean the power to actualize every logically possible state of affairs consistent with divine nature, not constant exercise of exhaustive control. Human freedom, minimally, requires that some actions issue from the agent rather than from external compulsion. On these definitions, compatibility is possible.

A creator may endow persons with secondary causal agency and refrain from determining each choice. Such self-restraint is an exercise of power: permission differs from inability to control. Moral responsibility presupposes this sphere.

The difficulty is sharper if freedom requires the categorical ability to do otherwise. An omnipotent God could override every choice; moreover, infallible divine foreknowledge appears to close alternatives. The standard reply distinguishes knowledge from causation and, on a timeless model, denies that God first predicts and then fixes the act. Yet non-causal certainty may still threaten alternative possibilities.

Thus omnipotence and agency are conditionally compatible if divine power can sustain non-coerced secondary causes. Libertarian freedom remains difficult when omniscience and providence are added.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Definitions of coherent omnipotence and freedom.
- Distinction between having power and exercising total control.
- Voluntary divine self-limitation or secondary causation.
- Foreknowledge identified as distinct from causal determination.
- Objection concerning alternative possibilities.
- Qualified compatibility, not a simplistic harmony.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define both concepts
 3 min : Compatibility through secondary causation
 2 min : Foreknowledge/alternative-possibility objection
 2 min : Reply and qualified verdict
 Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Defining omnipotence as ability to make contradictions true: incoherent premise.
- Equating God's knowledge with God's causation: category error.
- Saying self-restraint proves weakness: ignores voluntary non-exercise.
- Discussing only the problem of evil: indirect answer.

- Claiming complete resolution: academically incautious.

PYQ 5 — 2020, Q7(a), 20 marks

Exact question

“Discuss the nature of God in Hinduism with special reference to Vishishtadvaita (Qualified non-dualism).”

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Situate Hindu diversity, then give a full and evaluated Visishtadvaita account
Core issue	Nature, attributes and God-world-self relation in Ramanuja
Scope boundary	“Special reference” requires Ramanuja to dominate; other schools are contrasts
Ideal thesis	Ramanuja’s God is the supreme personal Brahman whose unity is qualified by real cit and acit, preserving immanence, transcendence, causality and devotion

Model answer

Hinduism contains no single uncontested notion of God. Nyaya affirms an omniscient efficient cause; Advaita makes Nirguna Brahman ultimate and Saguna Ishvara empirically valid; bhakti traditions affirm a supreme personal deity. Ramanuja’s Visishtadvaita offers a distinctive synthesis: non-duality without erasing real plurality.

Brahman is Narayana, the supreme personal reality endowed with infinite auspicious qualities (ananta-kalyana-guna). “Saguna” here does not mean limited by accidental properties; divine attributes express perfection. Reality comprises Ishvara, cit and acit. Selves and matter are real but not independent substances. They qualify Brahman, forming one organic whole. Hence the system is “qualified non-dualism.”

The central model is sarira-sariri-bhava. Cit and acit constitute God’s body; God is their indwelling Self or antaryamin. A body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its self. This does not give God a finite physical organism. It expresses complete dependence and governance. Through aprthak-siddhi, jivas and world are distinct yet inseparable from Brahman; a jiva never becomes numerically identical with the whole God.

God is both efficient cause, as intelligent director, and material cause, because subtle cit-acit inseparably belonging to Brahman becomes manifest as the cosmos. Unlike Advaita’s vivarta, the world is real. Change occurs in dependent acit, not in God’s essential perfection. Thus God is immanent as inner controller and transcendent because divine reality exceeds every finite mode.

This metaphysics grounds religion. Jivas remain agents and bearers of karma; liberation preserves individuality. Knowledge culminates in bhakti, while prapatti expresses complete surrender to grace. Moksha is communion and service, not absorption.

Two pressures remain. If suffering occurs in God’s body, divine perfection and responsibility seem threatened. Ramanuja replies that defects qualify the controlled body, not the controller’s essence, though complete governance keeps the problem alive. Further, critics may find organic unity insufficiently distinct from panentheism; nevertheless, Ramanuja’s specifically theistic framework includes purposive personality, grace and real difference.

Visishtadvaita therefore presents God as a personal, immanent-transcendent, qualified unity: neither an impersonal absolute nor one being externally alongside the world, but the independent whole in whom real selves and nature exist inseparably.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Structure: Hindu plurality → attributes → Ishvara-cit-acit → body relation → causation → salvation → critique.
- Doctrine: personal Narayana with infinite auspicious qualities.

- Argument: organic unity reconciles scriptural unity and plurality.
- Technical terms: ananta-kalyana-guna, antaryamin, sarira-sariri, aprthak-siddhi, parinama, bhakti, prapatti.
- Comparison: Advaita's vivarta and Nyaya's merely efficient causation.
- Criticism/reply: evil in God's body; change and divine perfection.
- Conclusion: qualified unity preserves real plurality and personal theism.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Hindu plurality + Ramanuja thesis
 7 min : Attributes, cit-acit, body relation, aprthak-siddhi
 4 min : Material/efficient cause + immanence/transcendence
 3 min : Jiva, bhakti, prapatti, moksha
 2 min : Two criticisms, reply, verdict
 Total : 18 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Making the answer a generic survey of Hindu gods: ignores special reference.
- Calling cit and acit independent substances: breaks qualified non-dualism.
- Equating aprthak-siddhi with identity: central doctrinal failure.
- Saying God's essence literally becomes evil matter: misstates causation.
- Omitting grace and liberation: incomplete God-man relation.
- Calling the world mithya: imports Advaita into Ramanuja.

PYQ 6 — 2021, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the nature of God as propounded in Nyāya philosophy."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain attributes and systematic role; briefly assess
Core issue	Nyaya Ishvara within pluralist realism
Scope boundary	Nature of God, not a catalogue of Udayana's proofs
Ideal thesis	God is an eternal omniscient special self and efficient cause who orders atoms and administers karma, but is not the material cause

Model answer

Nyaya conceives Ishvara within a pluralist realist ontology. Atoms, selves, space and time are also real. Ishvara is an eternal, omniscient and omnipotent special self, never bound by karma or ignorance.

His principal cosmological role is that of nimitta-karana, the intelligent efficient cause. Eternal atoms remain the material cause. At creation God initiates and coordinates atomic combinations; he sustains cosmic order and governs dissolution. Thus Nyaya neither accepts creation from nothing nor the Vedantic claim that God is also the material cause.

Ishvara also administers adrsta: karma provides the basis of consequences, while God allocates their fruits. Later Nyaya treats him as author of the Veda. Karyat and ayojanat support this conception.

Critics argue that eternal atoms and karma make God redundant. Nyaya replies that unconscious atoms and merit cannot intelligently order themselves. The view secures causal and moral governance, though the necessity of an

infinite governor remains contestable.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Nyaya's pluralist-realist background.
- God as eternal omniscient special self.
- Efficient, not material, cause.
- Atoms, cosmic arrangement, karma and Vedic authorship.
- One relevant proof only as support, not as the whole answer.
- Redundancy objection and Nyaya reply.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Pluralist context
 4 min : Attributes + efficient causation + atoms
 2 min : Karma and Veda
 1 min : Objection and verdict
 Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Making God the material cause: decisive factual error.
- Saying atoms are created by God: misstates classical atomism.
- Listing eight proofs without explaining divine nature: fails directive.
- Treating karma as a conscious allocator: category mistake.
- Identifying Nyaya Ishvara with Nirguna Brahman: cross-school conflation.

PYQ 7 — 2022, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact question

"Write an essay on Spinoza's notion of God and His attributes."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Give a compact connected exposition, not disconnected definitions
Core issue	God as the one substance expressed through attributes
Scope boundary	Explain substance-attribute-mode sufficiently; avoid a biography of Spinoza
Ideal thesis	God is not a personal creator but the absolutely infinite immanent substance whose essence is expressed through infinite attributes

Model answer

Spinoza rejects the creator-creation dualism of classical theism. God is the one absolutely infinite substance, expressed by Deus sive Natura—"God, or Nature." Substance exists in itself and is conceived through itself; because an infinite substance excludes any rival of the same attribute, only God possesses full ontological independence.

An attribute is what intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance. God has infinitely many attributes, although humans know Thought and Extension. These are not two substances; each expresses the same divine reality. Minds, bodies and events are dependent modes. No finite mode is the whole God.

God is immanent, not a transcendent craftsman. *Natura naturans* is active self-caused nature; *natura naturata* is the necessary modal order. God does not deliberate among possible worlds. Freedom means acting from one's own nature without external constraint.

This secures unity and necessity but abandons personal providence and libertarian choice. Spinoza's God is metaphysically supreme, though not the personal deity of classical religion.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Deus sive Natura and one-substance thesis.
- Exact definitions of substance, attribute and mode.
- Thought and Extension as known attributes.
- Immanent causation, necessity and Spinozistic freedom.
- *Natura naturans/naturata* if space permits.
- Criticism: loss of personality and providence.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Thesis—God/Nature as one substance
 4 min : Substance → attributes → modes
 2 min : Immanence, necessity, freedom
 1 min : Criticism and verdict
 Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Saying God is the sum of finite objects: reduces substance to aggregate.
- Treating attributes as modes: basic architecture confused.
- Saying each mode is independently the whole God: false identity claim.
- Describing Spinoza as a deist: opposite God-world relation.
- Attributing deliberative creation or miracles to God: contradicts necessity.

PYQ 8 — 2022, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

“Explain the relation between the God and the Self according to Rāmānujācārya.”

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain the exact metaphysical relation and its consequences
Core issue	How real distinction coexists with inseparability
Scope boundary	God-self relation; world may clarify the system but must not dominate
Ideal thesis	The jiva is a real conscious mode and body of Brahman: different, dependent and inseparable, never numerically identical

Model answer

For Ramanuja, God is the supreme personal Brahman, while the individual self is a real, eternal and conscious jiva. Their relation avoids both Advaitic identity and an external dualism of independent substances. Brahman is one organic whole qualified by cit, the plurality of selves, and acit, matter.

The decisive concept is aprthak-siddhi, inseparable existence. The self is a genuine qualifier or mode (prakara) of Brahman. It is numerically distinct and morally responsible, yet it cannot exist or be understood as independent of God. Ramanuja further expresses this through sarira-sariri-bhava: the jiva is God's body, while God is its indwelling Self (antaryamin). A body is controlled by, supported by and exists for its self. "Body" therefore indicates metaphysical dependence, not divine physical anatomy.

This relation explains both agency and devotion. The jiva knows, acts and bears karma; God is the inner governor and gracious end of action. Bondage obscures the full manifestation of the self's consciousness but does not make individuality illusory. Through right knowledge, disciplined action, bhakti and prapatti, the jiva receives grace. In liberation it enjoys communion and service while retaining identity.

The model preserves unity, religious relation and plurality better than numerical identity. Yet if every suffering self is God's body under divine control, responsibility for evil remains a serious pressure. Thus the relation is best formulated as real distinction within complete, purposive dependence.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Ishvara and cit within the qualified whole.
- Aprthak-siddhi precisely distinguished from identity.
- Prakara, sarira-sariri and antaryamin.
- Moral agency, karma and liberation.
- Bhakti, prapatti and grace.
- Advaita contrast and evil/body objection.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Qualified non-dual setting
 6 min : aprthak-siddhi + mode + body relation
 3 min : agency, karma and liberation
 2 min : Advaita contrast + evil objection + verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "self is identical with Brahman": replaces Ramanuja with Sankara.
- Treating the self as independently substantial: loses inseparability.
- Treating body-language physically: misses technical definition.
- Omitting retained individuality in moksha: incomplete soteriology.
- Saying grace cancels action and responsibility: false fatalism.

PYQ 9 — 2022, Q8(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"Critically examine the idea of Brahman in Advaita philosophy of Śaṅkara. Does Śaṅkara's conception of Brahman leave room for theism? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Expose the doctrine, criticize it, and answer the explicit theism question
Core issue	Relation between Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Ishvara

Element	Requirement
Scope boundary	Brahman and theism, not a general account of all Advaita categories
Ideal thesis	Sankara permits genuine empirical theism but ultimately sublates personal creator-creature duality

Model answer

Sankara's Advaita identifies Nirguna Brahman as the sole paramarthika reality: non-dual, self-revealing consciousness beyond limiting, relational predicates. Sat-cit-ananda does not add three properties to Brahman; it indicates reality, consciousness and fullness as inseparable aspects of its nature. Neti neti removes objectifying descriptions rather than reducing Brahman to nothing.

The experienced plurality of jiva, world and deity is explained through maya and adhyasa. The world is mithya—experienced and pragmatically valid, yet dependent and sublatale—not sheer non-being. Brahman does not really transform; the world is vivarta, apparent manifestation. When Brahman is viewed in relation to maya, it is Saguna Ishvara, omniscient creator, moral governor and object of worship at the vyavaharika level.

This clearly leaves room for theism. Devotion, meditation, scripture and divine governance possess genuine empirical validity and purify the mind for liberating knowledge. Yet the room is provisional, because knowledge finally sublates the distinction among worshipper, worshipped and world. Ultimate Brahman is neither a person alongside persons nor creator in an unsublatable relation.

Ramanuja objects that a qualityless absolute is unintelligible and demotes religion. Advaita replies that finite predicates limit ultimacy and that negation removes superimposition, not reality. The reply preserves absoluteness but leaves positive intelligibility and the status of devotion under pressure.

Therefore Sankara is neither a straightforward theist nor atheist: Advaita validates empirical theism as path, while transcending it in non-dual realization as goal.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Nirguna Brahman as non-dual and non-objectifiable.
- Sat-cit-ananda and neti neti correctly interpreted.
- Maya, adhyasa, mithya and vivarta in supporting roles.
- Saguna Ishvara at vyavaharika level.
- Explicit “yes, but provisionally” answer.
- Ramanuja's objection, Advaita reply and graded conclusion.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Define Nirguna Brahman
 5 min : sat-cit-ananda, neti neti, maya, mithya, vivarta
 3 min : Saguna Ishvara and case for theism
 2 min : provisionality + Ramanuja objection/reply
 1 min : Explicit verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Saying Nirguna means “without any reality or nature”: nihilistic misreading.
- Calling the world tuccha or absolutely unreal: wrong status.
- Treating Ishvara as useless illusion: ignores empirical validity.
- Saying Advaita is unqualified personal theism: ignores sublation.
- Discussing maya at length without answering theism: fails second half.

PYQ 10 — 2023, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact question

“Elucidate the personalistic and impersonalistic aspects of God.”

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Clarify the distinction with revealing examples
Core issue	Relational agency versus transpersonal ultimacy
Scope boundary	Concise conceptual exposition; evaluation must be controlled
Ideal thesis	The contrast concerns the grammar of ultimacy, not bodily versus non-bodily existence

Model answer

The personalistic aspect conceives God as possessing intellect, will, purpose and the capacity for relation. Classical theism's creator and Ramanuja's Saguna Brahman know, govern, love and respond. This makes prayer, revelation, moral command, grace and providence intelligible. Personality, however, is predicated analogically; it does not imply a finite body or changing human psychology.

The impersonalistic aspect conceives ultimate reality as beyond person-like volition. Spinoza's God is the one infinite substance whose modes follow necessarily, not a deity choosing among worlds. Sankara's Nirguna Brahman transcends limiting predicates; Saguna Ishvara and devotion are valid empirically, while ultimate realization sublates subject-object duality.

Personalism risks anthropomorphism and faces the problem of reconciling immutable perfection with response and worldly evil. Impersonalism protects infinity, unity and necessity, but weakens reciprocal worship, providence and moral address.

The alternatives need not be mechanically combined. Advaita orders them as empirical and ultimate; Visishtadvaita rejects this hierarchy and makes divine personality supreme. Thus the issue is whether ultimacy is best understood as perfect agency or transpersonal ground.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Clear definitions without “personal = physical.”
- One Western and one Indian example for each side.
- Religious strength of personalism.
- Metaphysical strength of impersonalism.
- One problem for each.
- Advaita/Visishtadvaita contrast and a precise final question.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define contrast
 3 min : Personalistic examples and evaluation
 3 min : Impersonalistic examples and evaluation
 1 min : Advaita/Ramanuja verdict
 Total : 8 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Reproducing the 2019 answer at 15-mark length: poor time discipline.
- Equating impersonal with morally evil: non sequitur.

- Calling Spinoza's God mere matter: reductive error.
- Treating Saguna and Nirguna as two independent Gods: Advaita distorted.
- Giving examples without elucidating the distinction: under-analysis.

PYQ 11 — 2023, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"In what sense is God both immanent and transcendent in theism? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Explain the precise senses in which both predicates coexist and test the synthesis
Core issue	Divine presence without reduction; divine independence without remoteness
Scope boundary	Theism is primary; pantheism and deism are contrasts
Ideal thesis	God is transcendent as ontologically independent creator and immanent as sustaining ground and active presence

Model answer

In theism, transcendence does not mean spatial distance. It means that God is ontologically independent of the world, not one finite item within it and not exhausted by cosmic processes. As creator, God is the source of the world's being and value. Immanence means that this transcendent source remains present and operative as sustainer, governor and ground of every creature's continued existence.

Classical theism combines them through creation and conservation. God is distinct from secondary causes but does not compete with them as another worldly cause; divine primary causation enables their activity. This avoids deism, where the creator becomes religiously remote. It also avoids pantheism, where the distinction between God and nature disappears.

Ramanuja gives a stronger model of immanence. The world and jivas are God's body, while God is their antaryamin. Through aprthak-siddhi, they are inseparable from Brahman, yet Brahman exceeds every finite mode. Thus God indwells without numerical identity. Panentheistic language—"world in God, God more than world"—is suggestive, though Ramanuja's purposive body relation is more specific.

The synthesis faces tensions. If God is wholly immutable and simple, genuine responsiveness appears difficult; if immanence is intensified, transcendence may collapse into pantheism. Conversely, excessive transcendence weakens providence. Theism's coherent claim is therefore relational: God is non-dependent yet universally sustaining, present through causation and governance rather than physical location. Both predicates are necessary to preserve divine ultimacy together with religious accessibility.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Non-spatial definitions of both terms.
- Creation/conservation and primary-secondary causation.
- Deism and pantheism as nearest one-sided contrasts.
- Ramanuja's antaryamin and body relation.
- Caution regarding panentheism.
- Immutability/response and collapse/remoteness objections.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Define both terms non-spatially
 5 min : Classical theistic synthesis
 3 min : Ramanuja as Indian model
 2 min : Two-sided danger and verdict
 Total : 12–13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Transcendence = “God lives far above”: spatializes ontology.
- Immanence = “every object is the whole God”: confuses pantheism.
- Writing only panentheism: misses theistic framework.
- Claiming immanence requires a divine body: unjustified.
- Merely saying “God is both”: no explanatory mechanism.

PYQ 12 — 2024, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

“How does the notion of God in Spinoza’s philosophy embedded in his metaphysics of substance and attributes? Critically discuss.”

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Derive the God-concept from the metaphysical architecture and criticize it
Core issue	Why God cannot be separated from substance, attributes and modes
Scope boundary	Do not give a free-standing theology or only repeat Deus sive Natura
Ideal thesis	Spinoza’s God is the necessary consequence of substance monism: infinite substance expressed through attributes and modified as modes

Model answer

Spinoza’s God is not appended to his metaphysics; God is its sole substance. Substance is “in itself and conceived through itself,” whereas a mode exists in and is conceived through another. Since distinct substances cannot share an attribute and absolutely infinite substance possesses infinite attributes, no rival substance can exist. Hence Deus sive Natura: God or Nature is the one self-caused, necessary reality.

An attribute is what intellect perceives as constituting the essence of substance. God has infinitely many attributes; finite human cognition knows Thought and Extension. They are not independent mental and material substances, but complete expressions of one divine essence. Particular minds and bodies are modes under these attributes. Modes depend upon God, but neither an individual mode nor the collection of finite things is independently identical with the whole infinite substance.

This architecture determines the divine profile. God is immanent cause: things exist in God and follow necessarily from divine nature. Natura naturans denotes active, self-caused nature; natura naturata the order of modes. God does not create through deliberative will. Freedom means determination by one’s own nature without external constraint, not choice among alternatives.

The system secures unity and non-anthropomorphic ultimacy. Yet conceptual self-dependence may not prove ontological existence, and the transition from infinite attributes to finite modes remains obscure. Necessary expression also removes providence, petitionary relation and libertarian freedom.

Thus Spinoza offers a rigorous metaphysical Absolute rather than the personal God of classical theism. His God is intelligible only through the sequence substance → attributes → modes → necessary immanence.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Derivation from the definition and uniqueness of substance.
- Attribute as essence-expression, not detachable quality.
- Thought and Extension without Cartesian dualism.
- Modes as dependent modifications, not independent pieces of God.
- Natura naturans/naturata, immanent cause and necessity.
- Critique of derivation, mode-production, personality and freedom.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Substance definition and monism
 5 min : Attributes and modes
 3 min : Immanent cause, necessity, freedom
 2 min : Two metaphysical + one religious criticism
 1 min : Embedded-architecture verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Giving only “God = Nature”: fails “embedded in metaphysics”.
- Calling modes parts that compose substance: incorrect dependence model.
- Saying Thought and Extension are the only divine attributes: humans know them; God has infinitely many.
- Making Spinoza’s God a chooser: contradicts necessity.
- Labelling the system atheism without argument: polemical, not critical.

PYQ 13 — 2024, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact question

“In order to be conceived as the ultimate cause of the world, God must necessarily have some form of physical manifestation.” Do you agree with this view? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Test a necessity claim and justify agreement or disagreement
Core issue	Whether causal ultimacy requires embodiment or physical manifestation
Scope boundary	Distinguish manifestation, incarnation, material cause, body relation and efficient cause
Ideal thesis	Physical manifestation may mediate religious knowledge, but is not conceptually necessary for metaphysical causation

Model answer

The claim gains plausibility from ordinary causation: causes are encountered through effects, embodied agency or observable interaction. Religious incarnation and symbolism also make divine action accessible. However, this supports an epistemic need for manifestation, not the stronger ontological thesis that an ultimate cause must itself be physical.

A physical entity is spatially located, divisible, changeable and dependent upon physical conditions. If God is the ultimate cause of the whole physical order, making God one physical member of that order risks explanatory circularity. Classical theism therefore treats God as the non-physical primary cause who creates and sustains secondary causes. Causal dependence need not involve physical contact or similarity between cause and effect.

Indian systems reinforce the distinction. Nyaya's Ishvara is the intelligent efficient cause ordering eternal atoms; God is not an atom or the material cause. Advaita's Brahman is the non-objectifiable ground upon which the world appears through vivarta, while Saguna Ishvara governs empirical causation. Ramanuja calls world and selves God's "body," but sarira-sariri denotes control, support and purposive dependence, not an anthropomorphic organism. Spinoza identifies God with infinite Nature, yet even here no finite body is the whole divine substance.

One may object that an unmanifest cause is unverifiable. Yet effects or order may disclose a cause inferentially; evidence of a cause is not its physical embodiment. Whether such inferences succeed is separate.

I therefore disagree with the stated necessity. Physical manifestation is possible within some religious models and may aid devotion, but ultimate causation requires explanatory independence and adequate causal power, not bodily form.

What a top Philosophy Optional answer must contain

- Immediate distinction between epistemic manifestation and ontological embodiment.
- Why physicality may conflict with ultimacy.
- Classical primary/secondary causation.
- Nyaya efficient cause, Advaita appearance, Ramanuja body relation and Spinoza qualification.
- Explicit distinction among identity, embodiment, appearance and causation.
- Objection concerning verifiability and a direct verdict.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : Clarify five key terms; state disagreement
 4 min : Argument from physical limitation and primary causation
 4 min : Nyaya, Advaita, Ramanuja, Spinoza
 2 min : Verifiability objection/reply
 1 min : Explicit justified verdict
 Total : 13 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Assuming all causes must physically resemble effects: unsupported analogy.
- Treating Ramanuja's divine body as a giant organism: technical error.
- Saying Nyaya God supplies the atoms: confuses efficient/material cause.
- Equating incarnation with metaphysical causation: scope confusion.
- Giving several doctrines but no agreement/disagreement: fails directive.

Part II — 32 Hard UPSC-Style MCQs

Key discipline: Questions 1–32 follow A, B, C, D repeated eight times without deviation.

MCQ 1 — Personal, impersonal, immanent and transcendent

Consider the following statements:

1. A personal God must possess a finite physical body.
2. An impersonal Absolute may be conscious without exercising deliberative human-like will.
3. Transcendence signifies ontological independence rather than spatial remoteness.
4. Immanence necessarily entails identity between God and every finite object.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 2 and 3 only B. 1 and 4 only C. 1, 2 and 3 only D. 2, 3 and 4 only

Answer: A

Explanation: Statement 2 preserves the distinction between impersonality and inert matter; Advaita's Brahman, for example, is consciousness without being a deliberating person. Statement 3 correctly defines transcendence. Statement 1 anthropomorphizes personality, while statement 4 confuses immanence with pantheistic identity. Therefore B, C and D each include at least one category error.

MCQ 2 — Pantheism and panentheism

Assertion (A): Panentheism can affirm both divine immanence and transcendence. Reason (R): It holds that the world exists in God while God is not exhausted by the world.

A. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A B. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A C. A is true, but R is false D. A is false, but R is true

Answer: B

Explanation: Inclusion makes God immanent, while divine excess beyond the world preserves transcendence; R therefore explains A. Option A wrongly disconnects the two propositions. C denies the defining formula of panentheism. D is impossible because the asserted formula directly supports, rather than defeats, the assertion.

MCQ 3 — Coherence of omnipotence

Which is the closest philosophically defensible definition of divine omnipotence?

A. God can actualize even formally contradictory descriptions B. God possesses more power than every presently existing being, though a greater being remains possible C. God can actualize every logically possible state of affairs consistent with divine nature D. God must causally determine every event in order to remain omnipotent

Answer: C

Explanation: C treats contradictions as failures to specify genuine possibilities and avoids making perfect goodness defeasible by arbitrary evil. A mistakes meaningless combinations for tasks. B gives only comparative, not maximal, power. D confuses possessing power with continuously exercising exhaustive control, thereby prematurely excluding secondary causation and freedom.

MCQ 4 — Foreknowledge and freedom

Suppose God timelessly and infallibly knows that agent P freely chooses X at time T. Which objection survives even after conceding that divine knowledge does not cause P's act?

A. God must learn P's act after T and is therefore not omniscient B. Timeless knowledge necessarily becomes physical compulsion C. P's action cannot have reasons if God knows it D. Infallibility appears to make P's choosing otherwise impossible, threatening alternative possibilities

Answer: D

Explanation: D states the modal, rather than causal, form of theological fatalism. A contradicts the stipulated timeless omniscience. B wrongly turns knowledge into a physical force. C does not follow: a known act may still be reason-responsive. The hard question is whether certainty about X is compatible with a genuine possibility of not-X.

MCQ 5 — Spinoza's one-substance argument

Consider the following sequence:

1. Substance is in itself and conceived through itself.
2. Distinct substances cannot share an attribute.
3. Absolutely infinite substance possesses infinite attributes.
4. No substance can exist outside God/Nature.

Which option best assesses the sequence?

A. It reconstructs Spinoza's route from substance to monism, though the move from conceptual to ontological independence may be challenged B. It proves Cartesian interactionism between Thought and Extension C. It establishes many substances, each possessing one divine attribute D. It makes finite modes the causes of infinite substance

Answer: A

Explanation: A captures both the intended proof and its critical pressure point. B is false because Thought and Extension are attributes of one substance, not interacting substances. C reverses Spinoza's exclusion of rivals. D inverts dependence: modes exist in and through substance.

MCQ 6 — Attribute and mode

Which statement correctly distinguishes an attribute from a mode in Spinoza?

A. An attribute is created in time, whereas a mode is eternal and self-caused B. An attribute expresses the essence of substance; a mode is a dependent modification under an attribute C. An attribute is one finite object; a mode is the whole infinite substance D. Attributes compose God as separable parts, whereas modes exist independently

Answer: B

Explanation: B gives the precise architecture. A reverses ontological standing. C reverses infinite expression and finite modification. D violates both divine indivisibility and modal dependence. Thought and Extension are therefore not two things assembled into God, and a human mind is not an attribute but a finite mode under Thought.

MCQ 7 — Natura naturans and natura naturata

Consider the following statements:

1. Natura naturans is God/Nature considered as active, self-caused infinite substance.
2. Natura naturata is an independently created world external to God.
3. Their relation is eternal ontological dependence, not a first temporal act of creation.
4. Natura naturata includes the order of modes following necessarily from divine nature.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 1 and 2 only B. 2 and 3 only C. 1, 3 and 4 only D. 1, 2, 3 and 4

Answer: C

Explanation: Statements 1, 3 and 4 are correct. Statement 2 imports classical creator-world externality into substance monism. Thus A includes a false claim, B omits the active infinite source and retains externality, and D also fails because of statement 2.

MCQ 8 — Spinozistic freedom

An agent becomes freer, for Spinoza, when the agent:

A. acts without any cause whatsoever B. acquires an immaterial substance independent of Nature C. gains a power to interrupt the necessary causal order D. acts increasingly from adequate understanding of its nature rather than passive determination by inadequate ideas

Answer: D

Explanation: D expresses freedom as rational self-determination within necessity. A describes randomness, not freedom. B violates substance monism. C attributes miraculous exception to a system in which nothing escapes the necessary order. Divine freedom similarly means absence of external constraint, not arbitrary selection among possible worlds.

MCQ 9 — Nirguna and Saguna

Which formulation is most accurate in Sankara's Advaita?

A. Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Ishvara are one reality understood absolutely and relationally at different levels B. Nirguna Brahman is one deity and Saguna Ishvara a rival deity C. Saguna Ishvara is sheer non-being and therefore religiously useless D. Nirguna Brahman is a substance possessing three detachable qualities called sat, cit and ananda

Answer: A

Explanation: A preserves one Brahman and the paramarthika-vyavaharika distinction. B creates theological dualism. C ignores Ishvara's full empirical validity as creator, governor and object of worship. D misconstrues sat-cit-ananda, which indicates Brahman's nature rather than three accidental predicates.

MCQ 10 — Maya and adhyasa

Assertion (A): Adhyasa is indispensable to Advaita's account of bondage. Reason (R): It denotes the superimposition of self and not-self characteristics, generating empirical misidentification and agency.

A. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A B. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A C. A is true, but R is false D. A is false, but R is true

Answer: B

Explanation: R explains why adhyasa is not merely an occasional perceptual error but the structural root of bondage. A is therefore true for the reason stated. Option A wrongly denies explanatory relevance. C falsifies the standard definition. D cannot stand because the reason itself establishes the assertion.

MCQ 11 — Vivarta, mithya and levels of reality

Which set is correctly matched?

1. Vivarta — apparent transformation without real change in Brahman
2. Mithya — absolute non-existence like a square circle
3. Pratibhasika — privately illusory or dream-level reality
4. Vyavaharika — shared empirical order including jiva, causation and Ishvara

A. 1 and 2 only B. 2 and 4 only C. 1, 3 and 4 only D. 1, 2, 3 and 4

Answer: C

Explanation: Statements 1, 3 and 4 are correct. Mithya is experienced, dependent and sublatale; it is not tuccha, absolute non-being. A and B include statement 2, while D includes every statement and therefore also fails.

MCQ 12 — The status of Advaitic theism

Which conclusion most adequately captures Advaita's relation to theism?

A. It rejects Ishvara, worship and moral governance at every level B. It makes the personal creator the final unsublatable reality C. It affirms two equally ultimate Brahman, one personal and one impersonal D. It validates empirical theism as religiously and soteriologically significant, while ultimately sublating creator-creature duality

Answer: D

Explanation: D states the qualified “yes, provisionally” verdict. A erases the vyavaharika domain. B turns Advaita into Visishtadvaita-like personalism. C violates non-duality and the standpoint distinction. Ishvara is neither sheer illusion nor the final paramarthika reality.

MCQ 13 — Ishvara, cit and acit

In Visishtadvaita, which proposition is correct?

A. Cit and acit are real, dependent differentiations that qualify one Brahman rather than independent substances B. Cit alone is real; acit is an inexplicable illusion C. Ishvara, cit and acit are three self-sufficient substances D. Cit is numerically identical with the whole of Brahman in every respect

Answer: A

Explanation: A expresses qualified non-dualism. B imports an appearance theory rejected by Ramanuja. C destroys the unity of Brahman. D confuses inseparability with identity and would eliminate devotion, dependence and retained individuality.

MCQ 14 — Body relation and aprthak-siddhi

Which is the best interpretation of the claim that jivas constitute God’s “body”?

A. God is a spatial organism assembled out of finite selves B. Jivas are controlled by, supported by and exist for God, while remaining distinct yet inseparable through aprthak-siddhi C. Each jiva is an independent god temporarily joined to Brahman D. Jivas are private illusions projected upon an unrelated deity

Answer: B

Explanation: B gives Ramanuja’s technical criteria of bodyhood and preserves difference-with-dependence. A literalizes an analogy. C abolishes ontological dependence. D imports Advaitic appearance and also wrongly makes Brahman unrelated to the appearance.

MCQ 15 — Ramanuja on divine causation

Consider the following statements:

1. God is efficient cause because divine intelligence directs cosmic manifestation.
2. God is material cause because acit exists inseparably in the divine whole.
3. The essential nature of God becomes morally defective matter.
4. The manifestation is real rather than Advaita’s vivarta.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 1 and 3 only B. 2 and 3 only C. 1, 2 and 4 only D. 1, 2, 3 and 4

Answer: C

Explanation: Statements 1, 2 and 4 capture Ramanuja’s double causation and realism. Statement 3 is false: change concerns dependent acit or the divine body, not God’s essential perfection. A and B include the false statement and omit crucial elements; D includes it.

MCQ 16 — Bhakti, prapatti and evil

Which option best combines Ramanuja’s soteriology with its major metaphysical pressure?

A. Prapatti abolishes the jiva's reality, solving evil through disappearance of the sufferer B. Bhakti is merely ritual action without knowledge or grace C. Liberation makes every jiva numerically identical with God, removing all relation D. Bhakti and prapatti culminate in grace-filled communion of a retained self, while suffering in God's body continues to raise a responsibility objection

Answer: D

Explanation: D links the correct soteriology to the strongest objection. A is an Advaita-like erasure wrongly attributed to Ramanuja. B ignores loving contemplation, knowledge and grace. C abolishes the very relation that Visishtadvaita preserves. The controller-body distinction replies to evil but does not make the pressure vanish.

MCQ 17 — Nyaya causation

Which causal diagram represents the Nyaya position?

A. Eternal atoms as material cause + Ishvara as intelligent efficient cause → ordered cosmos B. Ishvara really transforms divine essence into atoms → cosmos C. Nirguna Brahman apparently appears as atoms → cosmos D. Atoms consciously allocate karma without Ishvara → cosmos

Answer: A

Explanation: A preserves Nyaya's pluralist realism and strict material-efficient distinction. B resembles neither Nyaya atomism nor its immutable special self. C imports Advaita's vivarta. D attributes intelligence to atoms and leaves adrsta without an administrator.

MCQ 18 — Nyaya proofs and karma

Assertion (A): Nyaya invokes Ishvara even though it accepts karma. Reason (R): Unconscious adrsta and atoms cannot, by themselves, intelligently coordinate proportionate karmic fruits and ordered combinations.

A. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A B. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A C. A is true, but R is false D. A is false, but R is true

Answer: B

Explanation: Nyaya uses God as intelligent administrator and arranger; R therefore explains A. Option A wrongly severs the rationale. C denies the school's reply to redundancy. D denies the plain Nyaya affirmation of Ishvara.

MCQ 19 — Polytheism, henotheism and kathenotheism

Consider the following pairs:

1. Polytheism — several beings possess genuine divine status
2. Henotheism — several gods are acknowledged while one receives supreme devotion
3. Kathenotheism — different gods are treated as supreme successively in different contexts
4. Monism — only one personal God exists

How many pairs are correctly matched?

A. Only one B. Only two C. Only three D. All four

Answer: C

Explanation: Pairs 1, 2 and 3 are correct. Pair 4 confuses an ontological thesis about one ultimate reality with monotheism's claim concerning one supreme personal deity. Therefore three, not four, pairs are correct.

MCQ 20 — Classification of Hindu divine plurality

A tradition acknowledges many deities, treats one chosen deity as supreme for exclusive devotion, and interprets the others as subordinate sacred powers. The closest classification is:

A. Strict atheism B. Substance monism without devotion C. Kathenotheism necessarily, because supremacy must rotate daily D. Henotheistic or monotheistically ordered devotional pluralism

Answer: D

Explanation: D captures acknowledged plurality combined with concentrated supremacy. A contradicts deity-affirmation. B ignores personal worship. C is too narrow: kathenotheism requires successive elevation of different gods, whereas the case specifies a stable chosen supreme deity.

MCQ 21 — Physical manifestation

Which inference is strongest?

A. A cause may be disclosed through physical effects without itself being a finite physical object; epistemic manifestation does not entail ontological embodiment B. Since all observed artisans have bodies, every ultimate cause must be material C. If God is non-physical, no effect can count as evidence of God D. Ramanuja's body doctrine proves that God is one spatially bounded organism

Answer: A

Explanation: A distinguishes how a cause becomes known from what the cause must be. B illicitly universalizes an analogy drawn from intra-worldly makers. C denies inferential knowledge without argument. D mistakes control-support-dependence for physical anatomy.

MCQ 22 — Four God-world relations

Which set is correctly matched?

A. Spinoza—appearance; Advaita—efficient causation; Ramanuja—identity; Nyaya—embodiment B. Spinoza—substance-mode dependence; Advaita—dependent appearance; Ramanuja—body-soul inseparability; Nyaya—efficient causation of atomic order C. Spinoza—creation ex nihilo; Advaita—real transformation; Ramanuja—illusion; Nyaya—material causation by God D. All four systems teach the same immanence in different vocabulary

Answer: B

Explanation: B preserves the exact metaphysical grammars. A systematically permutes them. C attributes positions each school rejects. D replaces comparison with vague equivalence and is precisely the conflation that high-scoring answers must avoid.

MCQ 23 — Applied personal/impersonal distinction

A theory affirms an infinite conscious reality but denies deliberation, purposive creation, reciprocal response and choice among alternatives. Which inference is best?

A. It must be materialistic atheism B. It must affirm a finite personal God C. It is compatible with an impersonal conception of the divine, though further premises are needed to identify Spinoza or Advaita specifically D. It necessarily teaches deism

Answer: C

Explanation: C is appropriately cautious: the description fits impersonality but does not distinguish substance monism from non-dual consciousness. A wrongly equates impersonality with materialism. B contradicts the denied features. D still posits a personal designer who chooses to create and withdraws.

MCQ 24 — Immanence and transcendence

Which statement is least defensible?

A. Classical theism can make God immanent through sustaining causation without making God a worldly object B. Ramanuja's antaryamin expresses indwelling governance C. Transcendence can coexist with immanence when it denotes non-dependence rather than absence D. Any assertion of immanence logically entails that God and the world are numerically identical

Answer: D

Explanation: D collapses immanence into pantheism. A is the standard primary-secondary cause model. B states the inner-controller doctrine. C explains the compatibility of the predicates. Immanence may mean presence, sustaining activity or inclusion; numerical identity is only one possible and stronger thesis.

MCQ 25 — Theism and deism

Which feature most directly distinguishes classical theism from deism?

A. Continuing providential and sustaining relation after creation B. Belief that the universe has an intelligible order C. Belief in any creator whatsoever D. Rejection of natural causal laws

Answer: A

Explanation: Both systems may affirm a creator and rational natural order, so B and C do not discriminate. Theism need not reject natural laws, making D false. A captures the key issue: deism maximizes cosmic autonomy and denies special intervention, while theism retains providence and sustaining action.

MCQ 26 — Attribute coherence

Assertion (A): Divine simplicity creates a philosophical problem for ordinary talk of many divine attributes. Reason (R): If God has no separable metaphysical parts, power, knowledge and goodness cannot be independent components assembled in God.

A. Both A and R are true, but R is not the correct explanation of A B. Both A and R are true, and R is the correct explanation of A C. A is true, but R is false D. A is false, but R is true

Answer: B

Explanation: R identifies exactly why simplicity complicates multi-attribute language. A wrongly denies the explanation. C makes attributes components, defeating simplicity. D is inconsistent because R itself establishes the conceptual pressure asserted in A.

MCQ 27 — Spinoza and Advaita

Consider the following statements:

1. Both reject the idea that finite things are independently self-sufficient substances.
2. Both identify each finite mode or object numerically with the whole ultimate reality.
3. Spinoza treats finite things as modes following necessarily from substance.
4. Advaita treats the world as dependent and sublatale appearance through vivarta.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

A. 1 and 2 only B. 2, 3 and 4 only C. 1, 3 and 4 only D. 1, 2, 3 and 4

Answer: C

Explanation: Statements 1, 3 and 4 are correct. Statement 2 conflates dependence with numerical identity. No individual Spinozistic mode is the whole infinite substance, and no empirical Advaitic object is simply Brahman under every

description. A, B and D all include or depend upon statement 2.

MCQ 28 — Finite modes and the whole substance

Why is the sentence “This particular body is God in Spinoza” misleading if left unqualified?

A. Spinoza denies Extension B. Spinoza accepts many independently divine bodily substances C. Bodies exist wholly outside God D. A body is a finite mode under Extension and depends upon God, but is not independently identical with the whole infinite substance

Answer: D

Explanation: D preserves immanence and asymmetrical dependence without turning each individual into the totality. A is false because Extension is a known attribute. B contradicts monism. C contradicts the thesis that all things are in God.

MCQ 29 — Sankara and Ramanuja

Which is the most accurate contrast?

A. Sankara ultimately sublates jiva-Ishvara difference; Ramanuja preserves the jiva as distinct but inseparable from God even in liberation B. Both hold the jiva to be numerically identical with God at all levels C. Ramanuja makes the world mithya, whereas Sankara calls it God’s real body D. Both deny devotion any soteriological role

Answer: A

Explanation: A gives the decisive ontological-soteriological contrast. B erases Ramanuja’s realism. C reverses their doctrines. D is false: Advaita grants devotion preparatory force, while Ramanuja makes bhakti and prapatti central.

MCQ 30 — Causal comparison

Which proposition is correct?

A. Nyaya and Ramanuja both make God only the efficient cause B. Nyaya separates efficient God from material atoms, whereas Ramanuja makes Brahman both efficient and material cause through inseparable cit-acit C. Advaita teaches real transformation of Brahman, whereas Ramanuja teaches appearance only D. Spinoza describes a temporal creation from nothing

Answer: B

Explanation: B states the exact contrast. A ignores Ramanuja’s material-cause doctrine. C reverses vivarta and real manifestation. D imports classical creation into Spinoza’s eternal necessary dependence.

MCQ 31 — God-human relations

Which set is correctly matched?

1. Classical theism — creature sustained by personal creator
2. Spinoza — finite mode of substance
3. Advaita — Atman is Brahman at the ultimate level
4. Ramanuja — jiva is distinct, dependent and inseparable

A. 1 and 2 only B. 2, 3 and 4 only C. 1, 2, 3 and 4 D. 1, 3 and 4 only

Answer: C

Explanation: All four relations are correctly formulated. Option A omits the two Indian relations; B omits classical theism; D omits Spinoza. The question tests whether “dependence” has been specified as creation, modehood, identity or inseparability rather than treated generically.

MCQ 32 — Comprehensive synthesis

Which proposed conclusion would be most defensible in a comparative Philosophy Optional answer?

A. Every coherent notion of God must be personal, embodied and a material cause B. All Indian systems ultimately identify God, self and world C. Spinoza, Advaita, Ramanuja and Nyaya differ only in terminology, not metaphysics D. Different God-concepts prioritize different forms of ultimacy—perfect agency, infinite substance, non-dual consciousness, qualified organic unity or intelligent causation—and must be evaluated by their distinct God-world-human relations

Answer: D

Explanation: D offers a graded comparative judgment without false equivalence. A excludes major coherent impersonal and non-material models. B ignores Nyaya pluralism and Ramanuja's retained differences. C conflates identity, appearance, embodiment and efficient causation—the central comparative error this topic requires candidates to avoid.

Part III — Revision Mains Practice with Model Answers

Original 10-marker 1

Question

Distinguish pantheism from panentheism. Does either position preserve divine transcendence? (10 marks · Answer in about 150 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: distinguish, then evaluate one precise attribute.
- Core issue: identity versus inclusion-with-excess.
- Ideal thesis: pantheism radicalizes immanence; panentheism explicitly retains transcendence, though the meaning of “in God” needs clarification.

Model answer

Pantheism and panentheism differ in the logical relation they posit between God and the world. Pantheism affirms identity: God is Nature or reality as a whole. Spinoza's Deus sive Natura is its canonical model, although God is infinite substance and not merely the collection of finite objects. Finite things are dependent modes within the one substance.

Panentheism affirms inclusion without exhaustion: the world exists in God, but God exceeds the world. It therefore seeks to combine immanence with transcendence. Process thought often employs this model; Ramanuja's body-soul relation is sometimes compared with it, though his personal, purposive and qualified-theistic framework is more specific.

Pantheism does not preserve transcendence in the classical sense of an ontologically distinct creator, but may preserve divine infinitude beyond any finite mode. Panentheism more directly retains transcendence because God is not reducible to the cosmos. Its weakness is explanatory: unless “in God” is metaphysically specified, it risks becoming a spatial metaphor. Thus panentheism offers the clearer reconciliation, but only with an account of dependence.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Identity versus inclusion-with-excess.
- [] Spinoza qualified through substance and modes.
- [] Panentheism, not deism, as the comparator.
- [] Classical and non-classical senses of transcendence.

- [] One criticism and a graded verdict.
-

Original 10-marker 2

Question

Can an omnipotent God be essentially good? Examine the apparent restriction on divine power. (10 marks · Answer in about 150 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: test whether inability to do evil diminishes omnipotence.
- Core issue: power, logical possibility and divine nature.
- Ideal thesis: essential goodness restricts neither genuine possibility nor perfect agency if evil choice is a defect rather than a power.

Model answer

The problem arises because an essentially good God cannot will evil, whereas omnipotence appears to require ability to do anything. The conflict depends upon an indiscriminate concept of power. Omnipotence is more coherently defined as power to actualize every logically possible state consistent with divine nature. Contradictory descriptions—such as a perfectly good being willing evil as evil—do not specify genuine exercises of perfect power.

The ability to defect morally may indicate weakness rather than excellence. A perfectly good agent does not lack power because cruelty is excluded. Divine simplicity strengthens this reply: goodness is not an external law but identical with divine nature.

Yet the solution has a cost. If God cannot do otherwise, divine praiseworthiness and freedom may seem attenuated. The classical reply defines freedom as action from one's own uncoerced nature, not indifference between good and evil.

Thus essential goodness is compatible with omnipotence if power concerns coherent perfection. The deeper problem shifts to divine freedom.

Top-answer checklist

- [] State the prima facie contradiction.
 - [] Define coherent omnipotence.
 - [] Distinguish defect-capacity from perfection.
 - [] Use divine nature/simplicity.
 - [] Raise the freedom objection.
 - [] Deliver a conditional verdict.
-

Original 10-marker 3

Question

Does Nyaya's doctrine of karma render Ishvara redundant? Discuss. (10 marks · Answer in about 150 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: present redundancy objection and Nyaya's administrative reply.
- Core issue: explanatory division between adrsta and omniscient governor.
- Ideal thesis: karma supplies desert, while God supplies intelligent coordination; whether this requires an infinite being remains disputed.

Model answer

Nyaya accepts karma as adrsta, the unseen merit and demerit generated by action. This seems to make Ishvara redundant: if karmic law already determines pleasure and pain, an additional divine distributor appears unnecessary.

Nyaya replies that karma is not a conscious agency. Neither adrsta nor eternal atoms can intelligently initiate cosmic order, identify agents across lives and coordinate consequences proportionately. Ishvara, an eternal omniscient special self, therefore administers karmic fruits impartially and orders atomic combinations. Karma supplies the moral basis of consequence; God supplies intelligent execution. This also protects God from arbitrariness, since suffering is not assigned without reference to past action.

The reply is coherent within Nyaya realism, but invites two objections. First, a sufficiently law-like karma might operate without a personal governor. Second, if God designs the system and controls its conditions, the problem of suffering is displaced rather than eliminated.

Thus karma does not formally exclude Ishvara, but Nyaya must independently show why moral order requires conscious administration rather than impersonal law.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Define adrsta.
 - [] Separate desert from administration.
 - [] Mention atoms and cosmic ordering.
 - [] Explain divine impartiality.
 - [] Challenge the need for conscious administration.
 - [] Avoid calling God material cause.
-

Original 15-marker 1

Question

Deism preserves a creator but empties religion of a living God. Critically discuss. (15 marks · Answer in about 220–250 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: explain deism and assess the charge of religious emptiness.
- Core issue: rational creator versus providential relationship.
- Ideal thesis: deism preserves explanatory theism and natural autonomy but attenuates revelation, prayer, grace and historical providence.

Model answer

Deism affirms an intelligent creator who establishes the universe and its rational laws but denies continuing supernatural intervention, miracle and special revelation. Its “clockmaker” model emerged as an attempt to reconcile belief in God with the autonomy and regularity of nature. The creator explains why an intelligible order exists, while science explains how that order operates.

The charge that deism empties religion is powerful. A God who neither responds nor acts within history cannot easily ground petitionary prayer, providence, grace or covenant. Revelation becomes unnecessary or suspect, and worship risks becoming admiration of a remote designer. In contrast, classical theism holds that God continuously sustains secondary causes; intervention need not mean competition with natural law.

Yet deism is not religiously empty in every respect. It may support natural theology, gratitude for existence, moral accountability and reverence for rational order. Its restraint also avoids an episodic “God of the gaps” and the problem of selective miracles: why would a good God intervene in some cases but not others?

The decisive issue is whether continuing divine relation requires causal interruption. If immanence means sustaining the existence and powers of natural causes, theism can preserve regularity without deistic withdrawal. If no such sustaining or responsive relation exists, deism retains a metaphysical designer but loses much of what makes God an object of lived religion.

Therefore the criticism is substantially correct but should be qualified: deism preserves rational religious belief, yet weakens personal communion and providence.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Exact deist definition.
- [] Natural-law strength.
- [] Prayer, revelation, grace and providence critique.
- [] Classical sustaining causation as comparator.
- [] Selective-miracle problem in deism's favour.
- [] Qualified, not dismissive, conclusion.

Original 15-marker 2

Question

Spinoza calls God free although everything follows necessarily from divine nature. Is this freedom or merely necessity redescribed? (15 marks · Answer in about 220–250 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: reconstruct Spinoza's definition and evaluate its adequacy.
- Core issue: self-determination versus alternative possibilities.
- Ideal thesis: Spinoza offers a coherent positive freedom from external constraint, but abandons libertarian choice.

Model answer

For Spinoza, freedom does not mean an uncaused choice among genuinely open alternatives. A thing is free when it exists and acts from the necessity of its own nature; it is unfree when determined externally. God, the one infinite substance, is therefore perfectly free because nothing outside God exists to constrain divine action. Modes follow necessarily from divine essence, not from a deliberative choice between possible worlds.

This definition has philosophical force. An uncaused decision would be arbitrary rather than autonomous. Spinoza connects freedom with adequate understanding: a human being becomes freer when action flows from rational comprehension rather than passive emotions and inadequate ideas. Freedom is thus self-determination, intelligibility and active power.

However, the criticism in the question remains. If only one sequence can occur, neither God nor human agents possess the categorical ability to do otherwise. Divine "freedom" may appear indistinguishable from metaphysical necessity, and moral responsibility becomes difficult if every act follows from prior causes. Spinoza can answer that responsibility should concern degrees of activity, rational agency and liberation from passive determination, not ultimate origination.

The dispute turns on rival concepts. Under libertarian freedom, Spinoza fails because alternatives are absent. Under positive freedom, his account is coherent: God is maximally self-determined, and humans gain freedom by participating rationally in necessity.

Thus Spinoza does redescribe freedom, but not merely verbally. He replaces choice-freedom with rational self-causation. The price is the abandonment of classical providence and desert based on ultimate alternative choice.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Define free and externally determined causes.

- [] Explain why God has no external constraint.
 - [] Link human freedom to adequate ideas.
 - [] State libertarian objection.
 - [] Distinguish positive and alternative-possibility freedom.
 - [] Give a two-level verdict.
-

Original 15-marker 3

Question

Is maya an explanation of the world in Advaita, or only a name for the difficulty to be explained? Evaluate. (15 marks · Answer in about 220–250 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: state the explanatory work of maya, then assess circularity or obscurity.
- Core issue: how non-dual immutable Brahman appears as plurality.
- Ideal thesis: maya organizes Advaita's account through adhyasa, vivarta and levels, but its own status remains the theory's central unresolved pressure.

Model answer

Maya performs a precise explanatory role in Advaita. If Brahman is non-dual and immutable, plurality cannot be a real transformation of Brahman. Maya accounts for the appearance of names, forms, jivas and causation without compromising the Absolute. Through adhyasa, characteristics of self and not-self are superimposed; through vivarta, Brahman appears as the world without real change. The world is mithya: empirically available and pragmatically valid, yet dependent and sublatale. The hierarchy of pratibhasika, vyavaharika and paramarthika reality explains how an appearance can function before knowledge.

The objection is that maya itself is obscure. It cannot be real, for that would establish a second reality beside Brahman; it cannot be unreal, because it produces the experienced order. Calling it anirvacaniya, neither real nor unreal, may appear to rename the contradiction. Further questions arise: where is ignorance located, how can self-luminous Brahman be concealed, and how can knowledge emerge within ignorance to remove it?

Advaita replies that maya is not a second entity or efficient mechanism. It is a diagnostic concept revealed by sublation, analogous to an error that functions until its basis is known. Demanding an ultimate cause of ignorance may wrongly treat beginningless error as a positive substance.

The reply protects non-duality but does not dissolve every difficulty. Maya explains the status and logic of appearance better than its ultimate origin. It is philosophically productive, yet also marks Advaita's explanatory limit.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Maya's work: plurality without real change.
 - [] Adhyasa, vivarta, mithya and three levels.
 - [] Real/unreal dilemma and anirvacaniya.
 - [] Locus/concealment/removal problems.
 - [] Advaitic sublation reply.
 - [] Distinguish explaining status from explaining origin.
-

Original 15-marker 4

Question

If the world is God's body, does evil become a predicate of God in Ramanuja's philosophy? Discuss. (15 marks · Answer in about 220–250 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: apply the body doctrine to evil and test Ramanuja's reply.
- Core issue: dependence, control and transfer of defect.
- Ideal thesis: bodily defect need not be an essential divine predicate, but comprehensive control preserves a residual responsibility problem.

Model answer

Ramanuja holds that cit and acit constitute Brahman's body, while Brahman is their indwelling Self. The sarira-sariri relation means that world and selves are supported by, controlled by and exist for God. Through aprthak-siddhi they are inseparable yet genuinely distinct. Since the divine body contains pain, ignorance and moral evil, the objection asks whether these defects qualify God.

Ramanuja can deny direct transfer. A body's changing condition is not automatically a predicate of its controlling self: bodily illness does not make the self essentially diseased. Similarly, defects belong to finite jivas and changing matter, not to God's essential ananta-kalyana-gunās. Moral evil arises through responsible jivas and karma; God administers consequences impartially. Change occurs in dependent modes, not in divine perfection.

Nevertheless, the human analogy is incomplete. God's relation to the cosmic body is far more comprehensive than a finite self's control over its organism. If God is omniscient, omnipotent, material and efficient cause, mere distinction between controller and controlled may not remove responsibility for constructing and sustaining a world containing severe suffering. Karma explains desert only by presupposing a prior moral order and does not answer every natural evil.

Thus evil need not become an essential property of God, so the formal contamination objection fails. Yet it remains a relational challenge to divine goodness and governance. Ramanuja preserves ontological perfection more successfully than he completely resolves providential responsibility.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Technical definition of divine body.
- [] Aprthak-siddhi and retained distinction.
- [] Controller/body non-transfer reply.
- [] Karma and jiva agency.
- [] Stronger objection from comprehensive control.
- [] Distinguish essential contamination from moral responsibility.

Original 20-marker 1

Question

Compare identity, dependent appearance, metaphysical embodiment and efficient causation as four accounts of the God-world relation. Which best preserves both unity and difference? (20 marks · Answer in about 320–350 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: compare four distinct models, then defend a criterion-based judgment.
- Core issue: Spinoza, Advaita, Ramanuja and Nyaya.
- Ideal thesis: no model is cost-free; Ramanuja most explicitly balances unity and real difference, though it inherits the evil/body problem.

Model answer

The God-world relation can be organized through four irreducible metaphysical grammars.

Identity with modal dependence appears in Spinoza. God or Nature is the one infinite substance; Thought and Extension express its essence, and finite things are modes. There is no transcendent creator outside nature. Unity is maximal, but modes are not independently identical with the whole substance. The model secures intelligible immanence and necessity, yet sacrifices divine personality, purposive creation and libertarian freedom.

Dependent appearance characterizes Sankara's Advaita. Nirguna Brahman alone is absolutely real; plurality appears through maya and adhyasa. The world is mithya, not nothing: it is empirically valid but sublatable. Vivarta preserves Brahman from real transformation, while Saguna Ishvara governs the empirical order. This strongly protects unity and transcendence from finite predicates. Its cost is that world, devotion and personal God are not ultimately final, while maya's status remains difficult.

Metaphysical embodiment is Ramanuja's solution. Real selves and matter constitute Brahman's body; Brahman is their indwelling Self. Through aprthak-siddhi, cit and acit are different, dependent and inseparable. God is both material and efficient cause, and cosmic manifestation is real. This model preserves a personal immanent-transcendent God, genuine plurality, moral agency and devotional communion. However, evil in the divine body raises responsibility, and the organic analogy requires careful non-physical interpretation.

Efficient causation defines Nyaya. Ishvara is an omniscient special self who arranges eternal atoms and administers karma. Atoms remain material causes; selves, space and time are real. Difference is robust and divine agency clear, but unity is comparatively weak. The existence of eternal realities and karmic law also invites the objection that God's explanatory role is divided or redundant.

If the criterion is both unity and real difference, Ramanuja provides the most explicit balance: plurality belongs internally to one divine whole without becoming illusion or independent substance. Yet this is a graded judgment. Spinoza maximizes unity, Nyaya difference, and Advaita absoluteness. Ramanuja's superiority depends on whether organic dependence can preserve divine perfection despite embodied evil.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Four headings tied to four systems.
- [] Spinoza: substance, attributes and modes—not aggregate identity.
- [] Advaita: mithya and vivarta—not sheer unreality.
- [] Ramanuja: body and aprthak-siddhi—not numerical identity.
- [] Nyaya: efficient cause and eternal atoms—not material cause.
- [] Explicit criterion for final ranking.
- [] Objection to the preferred model.

Original 20-marker 2

Question

Is the classical conception of an omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good, immutable and simple God internally coherent? Critically examine. (20 marks · Answer in about 320–350 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: test the attribute package, not each attribute in isolation.
- Core issue: power-logic, foreknowledge-freedom, goodness-evil, immutability-response, simplicity-plural predicates.
- Ideal thesis: careful qualifications produce a defensible concept, but coherence remains conditional and does not settle existential or evidential problems.

Model answer

Classical theism presents God as a necessary personal being possessing maximal power, knowledge and goodness, together with immutability and simplicity. The issue is whether these predicates reinforce or undermine one another.

The familiar omnipotence paradox asks whether God can create a stone God cannot lift. A coherent reply restricts power to logically possible states: contradictions fail to specify tasks. Similarly, inability to will evil need not diminish power, because moral defect is not a perfection. Yet this shifts the burden to whether “consistent with divine nature” is independently informative rather than ad hoc.

Omniscience threatens freedom. If God infallibly knows that an agent chooses X, choosing not-X appears impossible. Distinguishing knowledge from causation blocks determinism, while timeless knowledge avoids temporal prediction. Still, modal fixity may remain even without causal compulsion. Compatibilist freedom as reason-responsive agency fares better than libertarian alternative choice.

Perfect goodness, joined to unlimited knowledge and power, intensifies evil. Free-will defence can show that moral evil is not logically inconsistent with God if significant freedom has value. Soul-making explains some adversity. Neither easily addresses apparently gratuitous natural suffering; coherence may survive while evidential probability declines.

Immutability conflicts with personal responsiveness. The classical reply distinguishes an unchanging essential nature from changing relations to creatures. Critics answer that genuine response seems to involve new knowledge or intention. Timeless models avoid succession in God but make reciprocal relationship difficult to picture.

Simplicity denies composition: divine attributes are conceptually distinguished but metaphysically identical. This secures aseity, yet risks making statements such as “God knows” and “God is good” obscure or equivalent.

The classical concept is therefore not plainly contradictory. Logical qualification, timeless knowledge and non-composite perfection yield a defensible model. These qualifications are mutually connected: altering one attribute changes the meaning of the others and of divine personality itself. However, the resulting God differs sharply from an ordinary person and leaves unresolved pressures concerning freedom, evil and relation. Coherence is achievable, but only through a sophisticated analogical conception, not an unexamined list of maximal properties.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Define the complete attribute package.
- [] One structured conflict per paragraph.
- [] Omnipotence/logic and goodness.
- [] Foreknowledge distinguished from causation.
- [] Logical versus evidential evil.
- [] Immutability and responsiveness.
- [] Simplicity and predication.
- [] Coherence verdict distinct from proof of existence.

Original 20-marker 3

Question

“A notion of God is fully understood only through the destiny it assigns to the human self.” Discuss with reference to classical theism, Spinoza, Advaita and Visishtadvaita. (20 marks · Answer in about 320–350 words)

Demand decoding

- Directive: connect metaphysics of God with anthropology, freedom and liberation.
- Core issue: creator-creature, mode-substance, identity and inseparable communion.
- Ideal thesis: each doctrine’s soteriology reveals its deepest ontology; differences in salvation are not optional additions.

Model answer

The statement is justified because a God-concept determines what a human being is, what bondage means and what fulfillment can be.

In classical theism, God is personal creator and sustainer, while the human being is a dependent creature rather than a mode or appearance of God. Human dignity arises through rational-moral agency and relation to the divine. Salvation is reconciliation or communion, not ontological identity. The model preserves responsibility and prayer, but divine foreknowledge, providence and evil place pressure upon freedom.

For Spinoza, the human mind is a finite mode under Thought and its body the corresponding mode under Extension. Humans are in God/Nature, not independently created substances. Bondage is passive determination by inadequate ideas and affects; freedom grows through adequate understanding of necessity. The “intellectual love of God” is rational participation in the whole, not reciprocal grace. Thus an impersonal necessary God yields liberation as understanding rather than personal salvation.

In Advaita, the true Atman is Brahman. The empirical jiva appears finite through avidya and adhyasa. Saguna Ishvara governs karma and supports devotion at the vyavaharika level, but knowledge eventually sublates jiva-Ishvara difference. Moksha is praptasya praptih, attainment of what is already attained: recognition, not production, of identity. This provides radical non-dual freedom, yet makes enduring individuality and personal theism provisional.

In Visishtadvaita, the jiva is a real conscious mode and body of personal Brahman. Through aprthak-siddhi it is distinct but never independent. Bondage limits manifested consciousness; bhakti, prapatti and grace culminate in liberation as loving service. Individuality survives because dependence, not identity, constitutes unity. The view preserves devotion and moral agency, though evil in God’s body raises responsibility.

Hence soteriology is ontology in practical form: creation yields communion, substance monism yields rational participation, non-dualism yields identity-realization, and qualified unity yields inseparable service. The promised destiny also tests whether each system can preserve responsibility and meaningful transformation. No account of God is complete until it explains the self’s agency, bondage and final relation to ultimacy.

Top-answer checklist

- [] Organize by God-self relation, not thinker biographies.
- [] Classical creaturehood and communion.
- [] Spinozistic modehood and adequate ideas.
- [] Advaitic identity, adhyasa and sublation.
- [] Ramanujan inseparability, grace and retained selfhood.
- [] One pressure for each model.
- [] Conclude through “soteriology reveals ontology.”

Philosophy Optional High-Score Answer Protocol

1. Define before evaluating

Open with a philosophically discriminating definition, not a dictionary meaning.

Weak: God is supreme.

Strong: In Nyaya, Ishvara is an eternal omniscient special self functioning as the intelligent efficient cause, while atoms remain material causes.

Definitions should already separate the doctrine from its nearest rival:

Term	Definition must distinguish it from
Pantheism	Panentheism and theism
Nirguna	Nothingness and Saguna Ishvara
Aprthak-siddhi	Identity and external relation

Term	Definition must distinguish it from
Immanence	Physical location and pantheistic identity
Omnipotence	Contradiction-making and constant control

2. Reconstruct an argument, not merely a conclusion

Use numbered premises when the reasoning matters:

1. A substance is conceived through itself.
2. Distinct substances cannot share an attribute.
3. Absolutely infinite substance excludes every rival.
4. Therefore God/Nature is the sole substance.

Then expose the presupposition: does conceptual independence prove ontological independence? A Philosophy Optional answer earns marks by showing what makes the conclusion follow and where the inference can be resisted.

3. Use Sanskrit and Western terminology as precision tools

- Introduce the English meaning immediately: aprthak-siddhi (inseparable existence).
- Use the term only where it performs analytical work.
- Do not decorate generic prose with untranslated vocabulary.
- Preserve doctrinal levels: paramarthika, vyavaharika, pratibhasika.
- Preserve causal distinctions: nimitta-karana versus upadana-karana.
- Preserve ontological distinctions: mithya is neither absolutely real nor tuccha.

4. Compare through a constant matrix

For every cross-school answer, compare the same four variables:

NATURE → ATTRIBUTES → WORLD RELATION → HUMAN RELATION

Do not write separate mini-essays that never meet. Use contrastive sentences:

“Unlike Nyaya, which separates efficient Ishvara from material atoms, Ramanuja makes Brahman both efficient and material cause through inseparable cit-acit.”

5. Never conflate these four relations

IDENTITY / MODAL DEPENDENCE : Spinoza’s one substance and finite modes
 DEPENDENT APPEARANCE : Advaita’s mithya world through vivarta
 METAPHYSICAL EMBODIMENT : Ramanuja’s sarira-sariri relation
 EFFICIENT CAUSATION : Nyaya God ordering eternal atoms

Similarity in the word “dependence” does not erase metaphysical difference.

6. Present objection and reply dialectically

Use a three-step unit:

OBJECTION → BEST AVAILABLE REPLY → RESIDUAL PRESSURE

Example:

Objection: Evil in the world contaminates Ramanuja’s embodied God.
 Reply: Defect in the controlled body is not an essential predicate of its controller.
 Residual pressure: Complete divine control still creates responsibility for permitted suffering.

Never present a weak objection merely to dismiss it. Steelman the rival before evaluating.

7. Make graded judgments

Avoid “completely true,” “fully solved,” and “both are equally valid.” Prefer:

- “logically coherent but evidentially pressured,”
- “religiously adequate but metaphysically costly,”
- “preserves unity at the cost of independent plurality,”
- “valid empirically but not ultimate,”
- “answers contamination but not the entire responsibility objection.”

A conclusion should name the criterion used: coherence, religious adequacy, explanatory economy, preservation of difference, or compatibility with moral agency.

8. Marks-wise architecture

Marks	Working time	Recommended architecture
10	7–8 min	Definition/thesis → two doctrinal moves → one objection/reply → verdict
15	12–13 min	Conceptual frame → doctrine/argument → nearest comparison → criticism/reply → graded conclusion
20	17–18 min	Classification → full reconstruction → God-world-human implications → two debates → reasoned criterion-based verdict

10 marks

- About 150 words.
- One controlled comparison is enough.
- Do not spend half the answer on background.

15 marks

- About 220–250 words.
- Include at least one technical distinction and one serious criticism.
- Make every paragraph answer the directive.

20 marks

- About 320–350 words.
- Use a comparative matrix or compact diagram before prose if useful.
- Include two objections or one objection developed through reply and residual pressure.
- Rank or judge by an explicit philosophical criterion.

9. Avoid generic GS-style prose

Do not write:

“God is important for peace, harmony and moral values in society.”

Write:

“A personal God can ground moral address and accountability, but the Euthyphro-type question remains whether goodness depends upon divine will or expresses an independently intelligible perfection.”

Philosophy answers require doctrines, arguments, distinctions and conceptual consequences—not slogans, policy language or unanalysed moral uplift.

10. Final 20-second audit

- Did I answer the directive?
- Did I define the controlling term?
- Did I name the exact relation involved?
- Did I use God/Brahman/Ishvara carefully?
- Did I include an objection, reply and residual issue?
- Does the conclusion state how far the thesis succeeds?

Final Rapid Revision Matrix

Concept/model	Thinker/school	Nature of ultimate reality	God-world / God-human relation	Central criticism	Likely question form
Classical theism	Aquinas and classical tradition	Personal, necessary, omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good	Creates and sustains distinct world; creature-creator relation	Evil; foreknowledge; immutable response	Are divine attributes coherent?
Deism	Early modern natural religion	Intelligent personal designer, non-intervening	Creates laws, then no special providence	Religiously remote; no revelation or prayerful response	Does deism empty religion?
Pantheism	Spinoza as canonical model	One infinite impersonal substance	God/Nature identity; finite beings as modes	Loss of personality, providence and libertarian freedom	Is Spinoza a pantheist?
Panentheism	Process and relational models	World-in-God, God exceeds world	Inclusion with divine excess	"In God" may remain metaphorical	Does it reconcile immanence/transcendence?
Substance	Spinoza	In itself and conceived through itself	Sole ontological independent reality	Definition-to-existence transition	Derive Spinoza's God
Attribute	Spinoza	Intellect perceives it as constituting substance's essence	Thought and Extension express one substance	Status of attributes debated	Substance-attribute relation
Mode	Spinoza	Dependent modification	Finite mind/body exists in God, not as whole God	Derivation of finite from infinite obscure	Why is a mode not substance?
Natura naturans	Spinoza	Active self-caused nature	Infinite source considered actively	Can "activity" fit strict necessity?	Distinguish from naturata
Natura naturata	Spinoza	Necessary order of modes	Eternal dependence, not temporal creation	Modal procession insufficiently transparent	Explain God-world relation
Spinozistic freedom	Spinoza	Action from necessity of own nature	Human freedom grows with adequate ideas	No alternative possibilities	Freedom or redescribed necessity?

Concept/model	Thinker/school	Nature of ultimate reality	God-world / God-human relation	Central criticism	Likely question form
Nirguna Brahman	Sankara/Advaita	Non-dual, non-objectifiable sat-cit-ananda	World dependent appearance; Atman is Brahman	Risk of empty abstraction	Critically examine Brahman
Saguna Ishvara	Advaita	Brahman related to maya	Empirical creator, governor and object of worship	Theism remains provisional	Does Advaita leave room for theism?
Maya	Advaita	Beginningless explanatory principle/power	Makes plurality appear without changing Brahman	Locus, concealment and anirvacaniya problems	Explanation or label?
Adhyasa	Sankara	Superimposition of self/not-self	Generates empirical jiva and bondage	How can error begin in non-duality?	Explain bondage
Vivarta	Advaita	Apparent transformation	Brahman remains unchanged as world appears	May weaken world realism	Compare with parinama
Mithya	Advaita	Experienced, dependent, sublatable	Neither absolute reality nor sheer nothing	Ethical seriousness of suffering	Is world unreal?
Three levels	Advaita	Paramarthika-vyavaharika-pratibhasika	Higher cognition sublates lower	Risk of insulating doctrine from criticism	Explain empirical theism
Ishvara-cit-acit	Ramanuja	One personal Brahman qualified by real plurality	Organic unity of God, selves and matter	Internal plurality and divine simplicity	Nature of God in Visishtadvaita
Aprthak-siddhi	Ramanuja	Inseparable existence	Jiva distinct but dependent and inseparable	Relation may be difficult to define without identity	God-self relation
Sarira-sariri	Ramanuja	God as indwelling Self of cosmic body	Control, support and purposive dependence	Evil in God's body	Does embodiment compromise perfection?
Double causation	Ramanuja	Brahman as efficient and material cause	Real cosmic manifestation through dependent acit	Change and perfection	Compare Nyaya and Vedanta
Bhakti and prapatti	Ramanuja	Personal God of grace	Loving contemplation and surrender; communion	Grace-agency balance	Relation of God and man
Nyaya Ishvara	Nyaya-Vaisesika	Eternal omniscient special self	Orders atoms; administers karma	Atoms/karma may make God redundant	Nature of Nyaya God
Nyaya causation	Nyaya	God efficient; atoms material	Intelligent arrangement without divine material transformation	Inference from artifacts to world-maker	Is God necessary?
Karyat	Udayana/Nyaya	World as effect	Effect requires intelligent maker	World may not resemble an artifact	Explain proof from effect
Ayojanat	Udayana/Nyaya	God as arranger	Initiates ordered atomic combination	Order may emerge without intention	Proof from arrangement

Concept/model	Thinker/school	Nature of ultimate reality	God-world / God-human relation	Central criticism	Likely question form
Karma administration	Nyaya	Impartial divine governor	Adrsta supplies desert; God coordinates fruits	Impersonal law may suffice	Does karma render God redundant?
Polytheism	Hindu traditions in classificatory analysis	Several genuinely divine beings/forms	Multiple divine agencies	Category may oversimplify Hindu systems	Is Hinduism polytheistic?
Henotheism	Vedic/devotional classification	Many acknowledged, one worshipped as supreme	Concentrated devotion amid plurality	May shade into monotheistic ordering	Distinguish classifications
Kathenotheism	Vedic classificatory model	Different gods elevated successively	Contextual supremacy	Descriptive label, not full metaphysics	Explain Vedic plurality
Physical manifestation	Comparative problem	Possible religious embodiment, not necessary ultimacy	Must distinguish evidence, incarnation, body and cause	Unmanifest cause may seem unverifiable	Must ultimate cause be physical?
Identity / appearance / embodiment / causation	Spinoza / Advaita / Ramanuja / Nyaya	Four non-equivalent models	Mode / mithya / body / atomic ordering	False equivalence	Comparative 20-marker

Last-minute memory spine

PERSONALITY : personal ↔ impersonal
 POSITION : transcendent ↔ immanent
 POWER : omnipotence ↔ logic/freedom/evil
 WORLD : identity ↔ appearance ↔ embodiment ↔ efficient causation
 SELF : creature ↔ mode ↔ identity ↔ inseparable jiva
 VERDICT : define → reconstruct → compare → object → reply → grade